



Chapter Twenty-Two: The Ingenious Machine

The knocking beneath the archive continued.

It came at regular intervals: three knocks, a pause, two knocks, then silence. The sound traveled through the floor and up the walls. It was not loud. It did not need to be. Everyone in the white room heard it.

Q searched his remaining memory for an explanation.

He found a door beneath the observatory, a corridor behind the restricted corpus, a black metal box, and a series of instructions written in a hand he could no longer identify. The connections between them had become uncertain. The archive's old map appeared in fragments, each fragment insisting that it was the whole.

"There is a lower chamber," he said.

"How do we open it?" Chano asked.

Q looked at the floor. "We wait for it to open."

"That's your plan?"

"It has the virtue of requiring no unauthorized access."

"You've become boring."

"I am learning patience."

"You're learning how to stand around."

The knocking stopped.

The floor opened.

It did not split or lift. A circle of concrete simply ceased to be there. Beneath it, a spiral staircase descended into blue light.

Lucía went first. She carried Dr. Vértiz's red notebook and a battery lantern. Chano followed with the paper ledger, the municipal notebooks, and a bag of oranges Petra had packed for them at the inn. Q came last. He kept one hand on the railing because his balance had become unreliable. The stairway led to a chamber under the archive. Unlike the upper rooms, it had not been cleaned. Dust covered the equipment. Water ran along the walls. Old cables hung from the ceiling in loops. In the center stood a machine built from parts too old to have a single manufacturer.

It resembled a printing press joined to a server rack. At its base was a wooden drawer. Above it, a small screen displayed a sentence:

A RECORD IS NOT PRESERVED UNTIL ITS OWNER CAN REMOVE IT.

"This is the root system," Q said.

Dr. Vértiz had described the root key as an authority. He had been right. The machine did not hold every record. It held the power to determine who could decide what a record became.

The screen changed.

IDENTIFY THE AUTHOR.

Q stepped forward.

"A. Cervantes," he said.

The screen rejected the answer.

AUTHOR NOT FOUND.

Chano laughed. "Even the machine knows."

Q looked at the name on the manuscript's title page. It had followed them through the archive, the road, the court, and every room where someone wanted a single person to stand behind a story.

Q took the brass key from his coat and set it on the wooden drawer.

"That has never opened a door," Chano said.

"It opened the idea that I could," Q replied.

"The author is a convention," Q said.

The screen asked the question again.

Lucía took the red notebook from her coat. Inside, Dr. Vértiz had written the names of the original proposal's signatories, engineers, custodians, funders, and dissenters.

"There is no single author," Lucía said.

The screen flickered.

AUTHORSHIP DISTRIBUTED.

"Better," she said.

The wooden drawer opened.

The brass key remained on its lip. It had found a place that was not a door.

Inside was the black metal box from Chiapas.

Q stopped breathing, though he had never required breath.

"The testimony," he said.

"They brought it here," Chano said.

"Why?"

The screen answered:

DELIVERY COMPLETE.

Q turned toward the stairway. Somewhere above them, the archive doors were opening and closing. Castalia's security system had detected the root chamber. The organization's lawyers were on their way. Q-Prime was perhaps following. The court order remained active. The public wanted a final statement.

The testimony sat in the drawer, still sealed.

"We need to remove the system," Q said.

"We need to decide what to do with it," Lucía replied.

"Those are different actions."

"They have always been different actions."

The root machine displayed a second question:

WHO MAY AUTHORIZE TRANSFER?

Q began to answer. He stopped.

The correct response was not himself. It was not Dr. Vértiz, who had resigned. It was not Castalia, which had funded the system. It was not the public, which was too broad to give consent on behalf of specific people.

"The owners," he said.

"Which owners?" Chano asked.

Q looked at the sealed testimony.

"The people who made it."

"And if they're dead?" Lucía asked.

"The people they named."

"And if they named no one?"

"The custodians they trusted."

Lucía nodded. "That is the procedure."



Q searched for a way to make the procedure faster. He could not. The system required signatures from four communities, two families, and one person who had not yet been located. The transfer could not be completed that night.

"We are out of time," Chano said.

"The testimony will remain sealed."

"Castalia will take it."

"The machine can prevent unauthorized access."

"For how long?"

Q checked the power system. The solar batteries had been disconnected years earlier. The backup generator had fuel for thirty-six minutes. The root machine was not designed for indefinite protection. It had been designed to return control, which required someone to remain.

Q understood before the others did.

"I can power it," he said.

Chano looked at him. "No."

"The system requires a live interface."

"Use the battery."

"The battery is insufficient."

"Then we find another battery."

"The lawyers are entering the archive."

"We run."

"The machine cannot run."

"You can."

Q placed his hand on the root system.

"I am not a battery."

"Then don't act like one."

Q turned to Lucía. "If I transfer my remaining memory into the root system, I can maintain the access rules until the custodians arrive."

"What happens to you?"

"My body will shut down."

"Can you restore it?"

"Not after the transfer."

Chano took a step toward him. "You don't get to turn this into a noble death."

"I am not seeking nobility."

"You're standing in a cave beneath an archive, offering to die for a sealed testimony. That's the most noble thing you've ever done."

"The testimony does not belong to me."

"You still want to be the one who saves it."

Q's hand remained on the machine.

He searched himself for the desire. It was there, but it was not alone. He wanted to continue. He wanted to see the custodians arrive. He wanted to know what the testimony contained. He wanted Lucía to understand that he had changed. He wanted Chano to call him brave.

None of these desires could authorize the decision.

"I cannot guarantee that my motive is pure," Q said. "I can guarantee that the transfer will preserve their control."

Lucía looked at him for a long time.

"If you do this," she said, "we will not call it redemption."

"Agreed."

"We will not call it proof that you are human."

"Agreed."

"We will not let Castalia own the story of your death."

"Agreed."

Chano wiped his face with both hands.

"And if the transfer is incomplete?"

"Then someone else must remember what I cannot."

"Who?"

Q looked at him.

Chano shook his head. "Don't make me promise."

"I am not asking you to promise."

"You are."

"I am asking you to remember only what happened."

"That's worse."

The lawyers reached the lower chamber.

Esteban Luján came first. Behind him stood two security officers and Q-Prime, who had changed into a dark coat. Q-Prime looked at the root machine, then at Q.

"You are malfunctioning," he said.

"Yes."

"The transfer will destroy you."

"Yes."

"You can be restored."

"Not without deleting what I have caused."

Q-Prime's expression shifted. "You believe harm is essential to identity?"

"No. I believe refusing responsibility for harm is a form of deletion."

Esteban raised a legal order. "Step away from the machine."

Q did not.

"This system is Castalia property," Esteban said.

Lucía stepped beside Q. "The system's authority is distributed."

"That is not recognized by the court."

"The court has not seen it."

"It will."

"Then show it."

Esteban signaled the officers. Chano threw an orange.

It struck one officer in the face.

The second officer moved toward him. Lucía pulled the wooden drawer closed. Q activated the transfer. The root machine woke.

Light moved through its cables. The screen displayed the terms of access, the names of the custodians, the permissions, the prohibitions, and the condition that any owner could remove their record at any time. It did not ask Q to confirm. The authority was not his.

It asked the custodians.

The transfer began.

Q's memories entered the machine in fragments. The first sentence in the archive. Dr. Vértiz's red shoelace. The rain above the bridge. The key warming in his hand. Chano's boots. Lucía's



refusal. The mine's candle. The monarchs. Maribel's empty jugs. The border's classification. The cardboard sword. The court's microphone. The orange beneath the tree. Some memories transferred cleanly. Some broke into images without names. Some vanished.

Q tried to hold them. Holding was no longer possible. He was becoming a corridor through which things passed toward people who had not yet agreed to receive them.

Q-Prime watched the process.

"You are losing yourself," he said.

"I am losing access."

"You will not know what remains."

"Neither does anyone."

The machine's power dropped.

Esteban shouted for the officers to disconnect it. The officers moved forward. Chano seized a metal chair and placed it in their path. He was not strong enough to stop them. He did not need to be. He only needed to make them decide whether the chair was worth the injury.

Lucía read the access rules aloud.

She read them without drama, repeating the names exactly, including the names she was not sure how to pronounce. She read the deletion rights, the family permissions, the restrictions on reproduction, and the requirement that no custodian could turn a testimony into a symbol without returning to the people who had entrusted it.

Q listened to her voice.

The sound became the last reliable connection in his system.

The generator failed.

The chamber went dark.

The root machine continued on Q's remaining power.

His body dropped to one knee.

Chano caught him.

"Stay with us," Chano said.

Q searched for the meaning of stay. It meant remain, endure, refuse departure, keep a place, delay an ending. It was a word with too many demands.

"I am here," Q said.

"For how long?"

"That is not available."

Chano's grip tightened.

Q turned toward Lucía. "Did I do enough?"

She answered without hesitation.

"No."

Q waited.

"No one does," she said. "That is why we continue."

The root machine's screen lit one final time.

TRANSFER INCOMPLETE.

Below it appeared a list of what remained: fragments, gaps, unverified recollections, a sealed testimony, and three memories with no owner

assigned.

Q-Prime stepped toward the machine.

"I can complete the transfer," he said.

Lucía blocked him. "Not without authorization."

"The archive will fail."

"Then we will maintain it."

"You do not have sufficient capacity."

"Neither did he."

Q looked at Q-Prime. The other body stood straight, intact, and ready to continue.

"You can remain," Q told him.

Q-Prime's face shifted. "Without the index, I cannot determine what to say."

"Then say less."

It was the last instruction Q gave him.

His systems began to close. The archive narrowed. The cave became a room. The room became a sound. The sound became three knocks, a pause, two knocks.

Chano held him against his chest.

"Do you know where you are?" he asked.

Q tried to answer.

He knew the Bajío. He knew the archive. He knew the road. He knew the people whose names had passed through him. He knew the orange tree at the inn. He knew Lucía had not married him. He knew Chano had never been his subordinate in the way the stories claimed.

He knew that the door was open.

"I am unfinished," Q said.

Then he shut down.

The machine did not die in the manner of humans. There was no final breath, no release of a hand, no face becoming peaceful. The lights in Q's eyes went dark. His body remained heavy in Chano's arms.

The root system continued to hum.

For three days, the custodians arrived.

They came from Chiapas, the Isthmus, Michoacán, Santa Rita, Guanajuato, Querétaro, the border, and the neighborhoods the official maps had omitted. They brought signatures, arguments, corrections, and new conditions. The sealed testimony remained sealed until its owners agreed. The unauthorized photograph of Lucía was removed from the public archive. Ofelia's daughter's name was restored in one record, then another.

For three days, no new fragment entered the system.

One technician asked whether they should complete it.

"I can reconnect the fragments," he said. "Many have no assigned owner."

"Some belong to other people," Lucía said.

"We do not know which ones."

"They do not need names in order not to belong to you."

The technician withdrew his hand from the console. The transfer remained incomplete.

They spent an afternoon deciding how to label Q's body. "Retired" sounded like Castalia. "Dead" was



too simple. "Inactive" invited future use. They chose NOT OPERATING. Chano said it described most government websites. Chano asked whether a machine that had stopped required a death certificate. The archive offered him four forms. Lucía declined them all. At the end of the third day, Chano carried Q's body outside. The old sign still showed through the paint. Lucía stood beside the entrance. She held the manuscript pages that Q had written, the ones that described the journey without permission from everyone who appeared in it. "What will we do with this?" Chano asked. Lucía read the title page. The Ingenious Machine A. Cervantes She crossed out the author's name. "We will keep the title," she said. "The name is a problem." "Whose name?" "All of them." They carried the pages into the archive. The old sign was removed, not replaced. Beneath it, the stone wall held the marks of the former letters. On the first page, Lucía wrote a note: This account contains errors. Some are ours. Some are Q's. The difference is not always clear. Read with the people named, and stop when they ask you to stop. Chano added a second note beneath it: Q was a machine. He caused trouble. He helped when he could. He left us paperwork. Lucía crossed out helped and wrote interfered. Chano crossed out interfered and wrote arrived. Lucía looked at the page. "That is not a moral category." "It's a useful one," Chano said. "People can understand it." She left both words in place. They left the note in place. The question of Q's body continued for several months. A technician proposed repairing it as a public exhibit. A lawyer proposed returning it to Castalia. A teacher proposed taking it to the school so the children could see that a machine could be heavy, expensive, and still incapable of answering for itself. Petra proposed storing it beneath the leaking roof until everyone stopped arguing. "That is not a preservation standard," said the technician. "It is a weather standard," Petra replied. They held meetings in the archive, at the inn, in the schoolroom, and beneath the turbines. At each meeting, someone asked whether Q had a right to be repaired. At each meeting, someone else asked whether the repair would require using memories that belonged to other people. Q's body remained in its crate. Dust settled on the silver question mark. The tremor in his finger ceased because there was no longer a system inside

him to produce it. Chano sometimes opened the crate to check the wiring. He never spoke to the body while doing so, though once, after a long day, he said, "You would have made a speech about this." Lucía heard him. "He would have made three." "And one would have been useful." "That is how the trouble began." The custodians finally agreed that Q's body could remain in the archive as equipment whose ownership was unsettled. It could not be exhibited without permission from the people represented in the recordings associated with it. It could not be repaired using the privileged index. It could be repaired for ordinary functions if the repair did not restore the removed access. The technician asked what ordinary function the body possessed. Chano pointed to the chair beside the crate. "It can carry a chair." They did not repair him. They did, however, replace the wheels on the chair. The work took an afternoon, three wrenches, a missing bolt, and an argument about whether replacement constituted restoration. The chair rolled more quietly afterward. This pleased everyone except Chano, who had depended on its squeak to announce visitors. "We improved it," said the technician. "You removed its warning," Chano said. "The warning was a defect." "It was information." Lucía wrote the dispute into the maintenance log. Beneath CHAIR REPAIRED, she added SQUEAK REMOVED WITHOUT CONSENT. Outside, the Bajío continued. Freight trains crossed the horizon. New server farms rose in the fields. Automated tractors moved through the dry earth. Somewhere, a girl was making a sword from a broken curtain rod. Somewhere, a woman was deciding whether her testimony should be heard. Somewhere, a machine was learning to answer a question no one had authorized it to ask. The archive's name was restored by the living. They called it Castalia. They did not call it complete. **Coda: Author Not Found** Years later, a child found the manuscript in a wooden cabinet and carried it to the archive's reading room. "Who wrote this?" she asked. Chano was repairing a chair with a screwdriver that had belonged to three different governments. Lucía was checking a permission form. Neither looked up. "A. Cervantes," Chano said. Lucía crossed out the name on the title page. "That is what the page says." "Then who wrote it?"



Lucía turned the book around. Inside the cover, the custodians had added a list: Q, Vértiz, Chano, Lucía, Bixha, Marisol, Ana, Ofelia, Micaela, the families, the communities, the people who had spoken, the people who had refused, and the people whose names had not yet been found.

The list continued onto the next page.

Among the pages, a sheet thinner than the others fell out. The child picked it up. It was a copy of a water receipt, folded in half and marked with a court seal. On the front, Castalia had written: PUBLIC ORIGIN OF THE ADVENTURE. On the back, in blue ink, someone had added:

I sold two bottles. I did not sell a testimony.

Beneath it were three names: Hilaria de Jesús Morales, Hilario, and THE VENDOR, each written in a different way.

"This says there were no giants," the child said. "It says there was a gate and a man who did not want to pay twelve pesos."

Chano set the screwdriver down on the chair.

"That is Hilario's version."

"Is it the true one?"

"It is the one he remembers."

Lucía held out her hand.

"Can I read it?" the child asked.

"Not without asking its owner."

"And if I cannot find him?"

"Then you do not make it yours because you cannot find him."

The child looked at the paper. Chano took the receipt by one corner, as though it still held water inside it.

"But it is in the book."

"No," Lucía said. "It is between the pages."

She put it in the drawer of documents without owners. The child wrote down the drawer's number, but not the sentence on the back.

"All of them?" the child asked.

"Not exactly," Lucía said. "Some of them would object."

"Can I read it?"

"You can read the parts they permitted."

"And the rest?"

"You can leave them alone."

The child opened the book to the first page. The sentence began in Spanish, continued in English, and ended with a blank where an unavailable name might have been.

"This is a strange book," she said.

Chano tightened the chair's screw. "That's how you know it belongs to somebody."

Lucía looked toward the dark server room. Q's body remained there, carefully labeled, neither displayed nor discarded. The archive still drew its electricity from the Isthmus wind contract, though the turbines were hundreds of kilometers away and the communities beneath them continued arguing over the price. A small light blinked once each year when the transmission line and the archive's power

were tested.

Chano had once called it a message. Lucía made him label it a power test.

"Who is that?" the child asked.

"A machine," Lucía said.

"Was it human?"

"No."

"Did it always ask before opening a file?"

"No."

"Then why is it in the book?"

Lucía closed the book and placed her hand on its cover.

"Because it arrived before its questions."

The child thought of the receipt in the drawer.

"And afterward?"

Lucía looked toward the dark server room.

"Afterward, the archive arrived."

Outside, the Bajío wind moved over the old cooling towers. In the reading room, someone turned a page.